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Migrants No More: Settlement and Survival in Mambwe Villages, Zambia by Johan Pottier
Review by: James Ferguson

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From these documents Brazza emerges as a man in a no-win situation. The letters and reports exchanged between him, his subordinates in Africa and the Colonial Ministry in Paris most of all reveal the ambivalence and contradictions of French colonial policy in Equatorial Africa. Massive expeditions were sent into a region where the terrain and rain forests made their management a nightmare, even for a wealthy colony, let alone the desperately underfunded French Congo. The development of local infrastructures was made impossible as the small budget was drained off to support grandiose imperial ventures. Brazza may not have been the best of managers, but he had little money to manage in the first place. Once competition among European powers had passed its height, with the failure of the Marchand expedition in 1898, the French Colonial Ministry abandoned the area to concessionary companies.

The documents are organised in three sections: the establishment of administration; exploration and expansion; colonial myths and realities. Drawn from public and private sources, they contain information far beyond the career of Brazza and his relations with French colonial authorities. African responses to European advance; the transition from slavery to alternative forms of labour; the impact of diseases such as sleeping-sickness and smallpox; the introduction of a monetary system, are other topics touched on in this rich collection of documents.

PHYLLIS M. MARTIN
University of Indiana

JOHAN POTTIER, *Migrants no More: settlement and survival in Mambwe villages, Zambia*. Manchester: Manchester University Press and Bloomington: Indiana University Press for the International African Institute, 1988, 223 pp., £32.50, ISBN 0 7190 2810 8.

This important book, based on field research in 1977–78, presents a wealth of new information on the social and economic circumstances of Mambwe-speaking people of north-eastern Zambia. Presented as an update of Watson's famous *Tribal Cohesion in a Money Economy* (1958), the book shows that the pattern of cyclical migration and rural prosperity Watson described for Mambwe villages in the 1950s no longer obtained in the late 1970s. With formal employment opportunities in Tanzania and the Copperbelt greatly reduced, impoverished Mambwe villages have devised a range of survival strategies that significantly complicate Watson's picture of stable agricultural villages built around a core of agnatically related men. Pottier shows that villages are more fluid and less stable than Watson reported for the 1950s, and that clusters of agnatically related women often play a key role in mobilising labour and organising increasingly important trading networks. He demonstrates that migration is today often linked with trade, and draws our attention to the role of small towns like Mbala in emerging new patterns of migration that are less closely tied to industrial employment. Crucial, too, is the role of cross-border commerce. Shut out of the shrinking urban labour markets, Mambwe today take advantage of their position astride the Zambia–Tanzania border to exploit price differentials resulting from different state policies. Watson's 'classical' migrants have become canny smugglers. There is a great deal of detailed material, too, on the social relations of food production. This involves attention to both inter- and intra-household relations, as well as to the complex local politics of agricultural production. Special emphasis is placed, very appropriately, on questions of food security. Pottier argues that commercialised hybrid maize cropping and the consequent abuse of the soil may now threaten the long-term ability of the region to grow its own food.

The book is a fine example of the value of empirical, close-up study of social and economic relations too often theorised in the abstract. It illustrates, too, the opportunities that are available to contemporary anthropologists to historicise the observations of older ethnographies through re-study. The rich material on such understudied phenomena as cross-border trade and social-economic interaction between villages and small towns leads beyond the traditional 'village community' framework, and invites a more historically and regionally sensitive analysis than Watson was able to provide. For example, following Watson, an older social anthropology concluded that the patrilineal social institution of the Mambwe enabled them to prosper under the migrant labour system. The matrilineal Bemba studied by Audrey Richards, on the other hand, lacked a male 'village core' and were thus unable to deal with the threat migrant labour posed to local agriculture. This contrast has become a textbook example of why local social structures make a difference in macro-economic processes. Yet the comparison was ahistorical from the start, based on static anthropological types ('patrilineal' versus 'matrilineal') abstracted from context. Pottier shows that 'patrilineality' has had only a very limited bearing on the local design of survival strategies, and argues convincingly that the differences Richards and Watson noted had more to do with the fact that Richards observed the Bemba during the Depression of the 1930s, while Watson studied the Mambwe during the boom years of the 1950s (pp. 179–809).

Unfortunately, the aspect of Pottier's argument that seems to have been most quickly picked up by many readers is the claim that the Mambwe are (as the book's misleading title has it) 'migrants no more' and that 'migration from Mambwe land has now come to a halt' (pp. 175–6). From this, some have even been led to talk of a 'Zambian post-migration economy'. Yet even Pottier's own data do not appear to support such an extreme claim. On the contrary, the dominant impression left by the book's presentation of a range of carefully assembled material is that a complex variety of forms of circulation between rural and urban centres remains a striking and central feature of the regional economy. Many writers on Zambian migration have succumbed to the temptation to set the complexities of the present against a stereotypical and oversimplified past in order to conclude that a 'classical migrant labour system' (which may never have existed in its supposedly 'classical' form) has now 'disappeared'. There is something of this in Pottier's claims for 'the demise of the migratory system'. Pottier's rich material might have been better used to advance a more interesting, if less dramatic, argument: that migration from Mambwe country may never have been as simple as Watson made it out to be, and that the decline of urban employment opportunities has brought with it not the end of migration but crucial changes in prevailing patterns of migration, trade, employment and agricultural production.

More theoretically, one wonders if Pottier has not, in updating Watson's classic account, remained caught too closely in Watson's outdated paradigm. Certainly, Pottier's material raises questions that go beyond those Watson asked. Rather than using this material to respond to Watson on his own terms thirty years later, Pottier might have done more to emphasise the theoretical shifts that make it possible to analyse this material in a fundamentally different way today. For example, Pottier presents a wealth of material pertaining to women, work and domestic structures. Yet this material could be related, not only to Watson's androcentric arguments (which Pottier does effectively), but also to contemporary feminist anthropological theory. With a more explicit attempt to move beyond Watson's questions, key topics such as *women's* migration (which Pottier follows Watson in neglecting) might have been developed in a more satisfactory way. Likewise, Pottier seems to follow Watson too closely in taking the ethnic group, 'the Mambwe', as his unit of analysis. This may facilitate comparison with Watson's

findings, but might it not also entail duplicating Watson's greatest mistake? Pottier's story is one of shifting economic processes whose logic was regional rather than ethnic; he shows clearly that the answers to his questions of rural poverty and prosperity 'had more to do with wider economic forces than with local cultural ideology and social organisation' (p. 179). Yet by taking an ethnic focus on what is really a regional predicament, and by treating the 'Mambwe' ethnic category as if it constituted a distinct 'society' and 'economy', Pottier seems to fall willingly into the same trap of 'tribal' reification that snared so many anthropologists of Watson's generation.

This is a valuable and well researched addition to the regional literature. It provides documentation and analysis of a range of important social and economic processes that bear on crucial questions of food, poverty and survival in contemporary Zambia. At the same time, it illustrates both the vitality and the value of ethnographic research as an empirical mode of investigation of local social structures and economic processes. It is a welcome and timely contribution to the revitalisation of a distinguished social anthropological tradition in the region.

JAMES FERGUSON
University of Michigan, Ann Arbor

S. I. G. MUDENGE, *A Political History of Munhumutapa, c. 1400–1902*. London: James Currey, 1990, 449 pp., £11.95 (paperback), Z. \$32.79, ISBN 0 85255 059 6 (Zimbabwe ISBN 0 949932 39 2, USA ISBN 0 435 08038 5).

Mudenge selected the title with care. It is a political history in the Afrocentric approach historians know from J. Ki-Zerbo. He follows Ki-Zerbo, who after all had a preface written by P. Braudel, in paying much attention to natural crises. But it is definitely not an account written with the strong ecologicistic, geographical or structurally historical bias which we find in the earlier chapters of the history of Central Africa edited by Birmingham and Martin (1983). Instead it reconstructs the political history and follows the political activity of individual kings and chiefs and other personalities with a strong Zimbabwe-centric bias. Such a book did not exist. It is clearly complementary to, and different in approach from, D. Beach's history of the Zimbabwe plateau c. 800–1850, first published in 1980.

Mudenge started his research on the Munhumutapas while teaching after writing his thesis on Zumbo and the Rozwi dynasty, and the book was therefore from the beginning the work of a mature scholar. For the period before the nineteenth century he seems to have consulted all the available published and almost all the archival evidence. For the second half of the nineteenth century and the first years of the twentieth the archival coverage is less full. Mudenge did not have the chance to see the Arquivo Histórico de Moçambique in Maputo, which has documents on this period, which, however, is marginal to the main theme.

Mudenge's original contribution is the analysis of a vast number of primary sources, the identification of Portuguese terms for items in terms of Shona culture and language, and the piecing together of evidence about the Munhumutapa side of the story. He also has a thorough understanding of Portuguese society involved in the contacts with the Mutapa state. In following up every available item of information the work becomes revisionist. Mudenge finds some virtue in the works of Father S. Welch, for long an outcast among historians of Africa.

Mudenge does not fall into the simplistic trap of the equations: anti-Portuguese = good and legitimate *v.* allied to Portuguese = treason. This is one of the stances in one of the earlier books produced in Mozambique for use in